

Yi Zhangyzhang51@usc.edu | <https://yzhang96.github.io/>**Education**

- 2020 – Present **University of Southern California**, Los Angeles, CA
PhD in Psychology, degree expected May 2025; GPA: 4.00/4.00
- 2020 – 2022 **University of Southern California**, Los Angeles, CA
MA in Psychology
- 2014 – 2018 **New York University**, New York, NY
B.A., Psychology (with Honors), Philosophy (double major); GPA: 3.85/4.00

Research Experience

- Aug. 2020 – Present **Social Learning and Choice Lab, University of Southern California**
(PI: Leor Hackel, Ph.D.)
PhD Researcher.
- Designed and conducted eight experiments (N = 2000+) to investigate how associative learning affects empathy, resulting in one publication and two conference presentations.
 - Designed and conducted online experiments, cross-sectional surveys, and a two-month longitudinal study to examine how social network dynamics influence group identification and well-being, resulting in one publication and two conference presentations.
 - Designed quantitative surveys, qualitative interviews, and an experiment with dyadic conversations to investigate how emotion regulation shapes responses to moral disagreements, resulting in one paper under review and one conference presentation.
- July 2018 – July 2020 **Social Cognitive & Affective Neuroscience Lab, Columbia University**
(PI: Kevin Ochsner, Ph.D.)
Lab Manager and Research Coordinator.
- Assisted in the planning and execution of eight research projects and managed their IRB protocols.
 - Created and modified fMRI experiment scripts in PsychoPy and E-Prime.
 - Ran fMRI experiments using a Siemens 3T scanner; collected, preprocessed, and analyzed behavioral and fMRI data.
 - Trained research assistants on recruitment procedures, MRI operation, data collection and analysis.
- Sep. 2017 – May 2018 **Social Cognitive and Neural Sciences Lab, New York University**
(PI: Jonathan Freeman, Ph.D.)
Honors Student and Research Assistant. Thesis title: “Perception of in-group and out-group prejudice between racial and political contexts: The role of social identity”
Advisors: Anne Hill, Jonathan Freeman, Ph.D.
- Designed and conducted a computer-based behavioral study.
 - Analyzed questionnaire and mouse-tracking data using R.
- Mar. 2017 – June 2018 **Social Perception and Evaluation Lab, New York University**
(PI: Jay Van Bavel, Ph.D.)

Research Assistant.

- Conducted multiple studies investigating the behavioral and neural mechanisms of intergroup punishment in political contexts. Conducted literature search, created stimuli via PsychoPy, and analyzed data using SPSS; completed training on fMRI operational procedures.

June 2017 – **Adult ADHD Program, NYU Langone Medical Center**
 Dec. 2017 (PI: Leonard Adler, M.D.)

Research intern.

- Conducted research on adult Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD).
- Performed prescreens for prospective patients and research participants and shadowed patient screening by psychiatrist.
- Assisted with data collection and analysis, and the archival of PHI and related research documents.

Manuscripts and Publications

Zhang, Y., Helion, C. & Hackel, L. An emotion regulation framework of interpersonal moral disagreements. Under review at *Emotion*.

Zhang, Y., Hackel, L. (*in press*) Generalization of rejection and acceptance in social networks. *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology*.

Zhang, Y., Hackel, L. (*in press*). Reward association with mental states shapes empathy and prosocial behavior. *Psychological Science*.

Cosme, D., Kang, Y., Tartak, J. C., Ahn, J., Corbani, F. E., Cooper, N., ... **Zhang, Y., ...** & Falk, E. (2022). Study protocol: Social Health Impact of Network Effects (SHINE) Study. PsyArXiv. <https://psyarxiv.com/cj2nx/download?format=pdf>

Conference Presentations

Zhang, Y., Hackel, L. (2025). Reward association with mental states shapes empathy and prosocial behavior. Data blitz presented at *Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2025 Conference*, Denver, CO.

Zhang, Y., Hackel, L. (2024). Emotion regulation predicts response to moral disagreements in relational contexts. Poster presented at *Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2024 Conference*, San Diego, CA.

Zhang, Y., Hackel, L. (2023). Anticipated acceptance mediates the relationship between network density and social identification. Poster presented at *Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2023 Conference*, Atlanta, GA.

Zhang, Y., Hackel, L. (2022). Generalized response to social rejection and acceptance in social networks. Poster presented at *Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2022 Conference*, San Francisco, CA.

Zhang, Y., Hackel, L. (2021). Learning empathy via Pavlovian conditioning. Poster presented at *Society for Affective Science 2021 Conference*, Online.

Zhang, Y., Stanoi, O., Ochsner, K., & Falk, E. (2020). Enhanced craving for alcohol in social context predicts centrality in undergraduate social network. Poster to be presented at the *Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2020 Conference*, New Orleans, LA.

Zhang, Y., Hill, A., & Freeman, J. (2018). Social identity shapes perception of in-group and out-group bias between racial and political contexts. Talk presented at *NYU Undergraduate Research Conference*, New York, NY.

Teaching Experience

Spring 2024	Guest lecturer for PSYC-355, Social Psychology
Spring 2023 & Fall 2025	Teaching assistant for PSYC-100, Introduction to Psychology
Fall 2022 & Fall 2023	Teaching assistant for PSYC-274, Statistics
Spring 2022, 2024, & 2025	Teaching assistant for PSYC-165, Drugs, Behavior, and Society

Skills

Research Methodologies

- Behavioral: online survey, in-lab experiment, social network analysis, natural language processing, ecological momentary assessment (EMA).
- Neuroimaging: fMRI data collection, processing, and analysis.

Programming

- R, Python, SPSS, Bash, SQL, Matlab, Javascript, HTML/CSS

Software

- Qualtrics, Microsoft Office, Adobe Photoshop.
- FSL, PsychoPy, E-Prime, PsychToolbox, MouseTracker.

Science Writing and Communication

Zhang, Y. (July 2025) Reimagining empathy in the era of AI. Medium.

<https://medium.com/@yzhang51/reimagining-empathy-in-the-era-of-ai-fde1117bec12>

Zhang, Y. (May 2022) Do we still need empathy in a fractured world? *Neu-reality* (神经现实).

Honors and Awards

2024	USC Psychology Department Doctoral Research Grant Award (\$1,800)
2020 - 25	USC Psychology Department Travel Grant Award (\$1,250)
2022	Honorable mention, APS Student Grant
2017 – 18	Psi Chi, New York University Chapter
2017 – 18	Dean's Undergraduate Research Fund (DURF), New York University
2014 – 18	Dean's List for Academic Year, New York University

Professional Memberships

2018 – Present	Member, <i>Society for Personality and Social Psychology</i>
2021 – Present	Member, <i>Society for Affective Science</i>

2021 – Present Member, *Association for Psychological Science*